

Segway, an electric scooter that, it was prophesized, would change the morphology of cities, and many others. As I was mentally writing these lines I saw a *Time* magazine cover at an airport stand announcing the “meaningful inventions” of the year. These inventions seemed to be meaningful as of the issue date, or perhaps for a couple of weeks after. Journalists can teach us how to *not* learn.

HOW TO PREDICT YOUR PREDICTIONS!

This brings us to Sir Doktor Professor Karl Raimund Popper’s attack on historicism. As I said in [Chapter 5](#), this was his most significant insight, but it remains his least known. People who do not really know his work tend to focus on Popperian falsification, which addresses the verification or nonverification of claims. This focus obscures his central idea: he made skepticism a *method*, he made of a skeptic someone constructive.

Just as Karl Marx wrote, in great irritation, a diatribe called *The Misery of Philosophy* in response to Proudhon’s *The Philosophy of Misery*, Popper, irritated by some of the philosophers of his time who believed in the scientific understanding of history, wrote, as a pun, *The Misery of Historicism* (which has been translated as *The Poverty of Historicism*).^{*}

Popper’s insight concerns the limitations in forecasting historical events and the need to downgrade “soft” areas such as history and social science to a level slightly above aesthetics and entertainment, like butterfly or coin collecting. (Popper, having received a classical Viennese education, didn’t go quite that far; I do. I am from Amiouun.) What we call here soft historical sciences are narrative dependent studies.

Popper’s central argument is that in order to predict historical events you need to predict technological innovation, itself fundamentally unpredictable.

“Fundamentally” unpredictable? I will explain what he means using a modern framework. Consider the following property of knowledge: If you expect that you will know *tomorrow* with certainty that your boyfriend has been cheating on you all this time, then you know *today* with certainty that your boyfriend is cheating on you and will take action *today*, say, by grabbing a pair of scissors and angrily cutting all his Ferragamo ties in half. You won’t tell yourself, This is what I will figure out tomorrow, but today is different so I will ignore the information and have a pleasant dinner. This point can be generalized to all forms of knowledge. There is actually a law in statistics called the *law of iterated expectations*, which I outline here in its strong form: if I expect to expect something at some date in the future, then I already expect that something at present.